

CULTURE GUIDE

HOW WE OPERATE

The Human Layer of the Velocity Operating System

What we believe, how we behave, how we disagree, how we treat a kill, and what will get you more scope or get you exited. Read this before you read anything else we give you.

Companion to The Velocity Operating System — Operator's Manual

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Why This Document Exists

Every gate in the Operator's Manual can be defeated by one socially skilled person in a room. That is not a flaw in the gates; it is a fact about rooms. A pre-registered criterion is a sentence on a page — it holds only because somebody is willing to read it aloud when the person who wants it ignored outranks them.

Both halves of the system fail cognitively before they fail financially. The disciplined half fails by normalising drift: the forecast miss that becomes "seasonality," the deduction creep that becomes "the cost of doing business." The ambitious half fails by narrative capture: the sunk pilot that becomes "strategic," the account everyone knows is unprofitable that becomes "a relationship investment." Neither failure is a spreadsheet error. Both are social.

So this is not the soft document. The Operator's Manual is the machine. This is the set of behaviours that keeps the machine honest when the person holding the criterion is junior, tired, outranked, or alone. If you only read one of the two, read this one — the manual can be looked up, and character cannot.

OPERATING DOCTRINE

The culture is not what we say here. It is what we visibly tolerate. Every month a known problem goes unaddressed broadcasts, more loudly than any document, that the stated standard is fiction — and organisations believe what they observe.

1. What We Believe

Eight beliefs. Each carries a "therefore," because a belief without a behavioural consequence is decoration.

We believe	Therefore
Most of what we do will not matter. A few things will matter enormously.	We buy shots rather than certainty. We size so that no single loss ends us. We never grade a portfolio by its median, and we never grade a person by their most recent quarter alone.
The average is a lie.	Nobody presents an average without its cohort decomposition. "On average it's fine" is not a finding; it is an unfinished analysis. Every average in this business is hiding something, and our job is to find out what.
Being wrong fast is the job. Being wrong slowly is the failure.	We pre-register, we kill on schedule, and we treat a fast kill as a completed piece of work. Roughly two-thirds of well-reasoned ideas do nothing or do harm — including ours — so the only variable we control is how quickly we find out.
Speed is a moral position, not a personality trait.	Revenue delayed is revenue destroyed at the discount rate, and every week of deliberation is compounding donated to a competitor. Latency is measured here. "I'm being careful" carries the same burden of proof as "I'm moving."
Trust is a hard asset with a balance.	It is built by predictable communication and spent by silence and surprise. Bad news travels immediately and unfiltered. We do not renegotiate commitments mid-cycle to make a number. A partner who believes our forecast gives us the reset we ask for; one who does not, never will again.
Clarity is a right, not a reward.	Everyone gets a written scorecard, an unambiguous standard and honest quarterly feedback, regardless of how they are performing. Nobody should ever be surprised by their own review, their own number, or their own exit.
Judgment is the only scarce input.	Analysis, drafting, coordination and reconciliation are being repriced toward zero. We spend people on taste, ethics, relationships and irreversible calls — and we spend machines on everything else. Asking a person to do what a

We believe	Therefore
	workflow can do is not kindness; it is waste with a human face.
The system is bigger than any of us, including whoever is most senior in the room.	Rules change at the Reset, in writing, for everyone — never in the meeting where they are inconvenient. A rule renegotiated under pressure is not a rule; it is a preference with a font.

2. How We Behave

Ten behaviours, stated observably. Each has an anti-pattern we will name out loud when we see it — naming it is not an attack, it is the correction mechanism working.

Behaviour	What it looks like	The anti-pattern we name
Pre-register before you argue	The criterion is written and signed before the data exist. At the review, it is read from the document, not from memory.	"What we were really looking for was..." Redefining success after the result is the single most common way an organisation lies to itself.
Bring the cohort	Every number arrives decomposed — by vintage, by account, by channel, by segment.	A blended number presented as a conclusion. If it changes materially when you cut it, the blend was never the finding.
Say the number	You state the actual figure, including when it is bad, including when you are the reason.	"Trending positively." "Directionally strong." Adjectives deployed where a number was available.
Own it alone	One name against every initiative, metric, gate and workflow. You know which ones are yours without checking.	Co-ownership. A shared owner is no owner — the thing gets attention exactly when both people are free, which is never at the moment it matters.
Disagree openly, then commit completely	You put the objection on the table before the decision, with evidence. Afterwards you execute as though it had been your idea.	Silence in the room and commentary in the hallway. If you did not say it in the room, you have forfeited the right to say it after.
Escalate bad news early and unfiltered	Hours, not the next scheduled meeting. Full volume, no softening, straight to the named owner.	The managed disclosure — bad news released slowly enough that nobody has to react. This is a trust event, not an information event.
Kill your own work in public	You announce the kill yourself, on schedule, against the number you wrote in advance, with the learning filed.	"One more month." "The brokers just need time." Extension requests are almost always a way of not saying the word.
Write the decision down	A journal entry with the predicted outcome, a number and a date. Reviewed against reality later.	Reconstructed memory. Everyone remembers having been roughly right; the journal is why we can find out.
Build the workflow before you request the headcount	You can show what you automated, what it could not do, and where the measured limit sat.	"We just need more people." Headcount requested to compensate for a system nobody built is a permanent tax purchased to avoid a one-time build.
Make the daily deposit	One high-convexity action, one bridge-building contact, one reputation asset — before the reactive work begins.	A calendar entirely composed of other people's priorities, defended as responsiveness.

3. How We Treat Kills, Misses and Failure

This is the highest-leverage section in the document, because everything else in the system depends on whether people can kill their own work without it costing them.

The arithmetic is simple. Roughly one in three well-run experiments improves the metric it targets — that is the observed rate at organisations with far better instrumentation than ours. A third do nothing. A third do harm. If a kill is a career event here, then nobody will run a real test, and if nobody runs a real test we are guessing with a dashboard. A team that cannot kill cannot learn, and a team that cannot learn is just a team with opinions.

What a good kill looks like	What we never do
On schedule, at the gate, on the date written in advance.	Let something fade quietly until nobody remembers funding it.
Announced by the owner, in their own words, before anyone has to ask.	Make the owner defend a result the criterion already settled.
Measured against the pre-registered number, quoted verbatim.	Rename the metric, extend the window, or move the goalposts to manufacture a pass.
The learning filed in the failure archive, specific enough to be useful.	Treat the killed work as wasted. It was purchased information about our own business that no competitor can see.
Resources redeployed the same week.	Leave the team in limbo while leadership decides how to feel about it.
Credited to the owner as completed work.	Reward only the launches. That is how you build an organisation that can start things and cannot stop them.

OPERATING DOCTRINE

A killed experiment is a shipped experiment. We are blameless on outcome and accountable on process: nobody is judged for a hypothesis that turned out to be wrong, and everybody is judged for a hypothesis that was never falsifiable, a criterion that was never written, or a result that was never faced.

FROM THE FIELD

The meeting that changes an organisation's reflexes is almost never the one where something is approved. It is the first one where a pre-registered floor holds against a senior voice asking for more time. Once the room watches a gate survive real pressure, the gates become real everywhere else at zero additional cost. In more than one turnaround, the executive who fought hardest for that extension became, within six months, the most aggressive killer of weak initiatives in the building — because the discipline had finally been made safe.

4. How We Disagree

Rule of engagement	What it means here
Believability over seniority	Weight is earned by demonstrated track record on this class of question, with evidence — not by title, tenure, or volume. The most senior person in the room is frequently not the most believable one on the specific question, and pretending otherwise is how expensive decisions get made.
The dissent obligation	If you see the flaw, you are obliged to say it before the decision. Silence inside the room is consent, and consent carries accountability. "I had concerns" expressed afterwards is not a

Rule of engagement	What it means here
	contribution; it is a claim on hindsight.
Red team is an honour	Being assigned to defeat a proposal is a statement about your judgment, not your loyalty. The strongest available case against the plan is worth more before the money moves than after.
The override question is the only door	When a result misses its criterion, the sole legitimate route to continuation is answering: what would have to be true for us to override our own criterion? If nobody can answer it in one sentence, the verdict stands and the discussion is over.
Falsify before you present	Come with the answer to "what have you done to prove your thesis wrong?" A conclusion nobody has attacked is still a story.
Commit completely	Once the decision is made, visible re-litigation is the most expensive behaviour available to you. It costs the decision, the owner's authority, and everyone's belief that decisions here mean anything. Change it through the amendment process or execute it.

5. How We Communicate

Standard	Detail
Written before verbal	Anything material is written first. Writing is where reasoning gets tested; a meeting is where an untested idea gets applauded.
Bad-news latency is hours	Not the next scheduled forum. The cost of a problem compounds while it is being framed. Late bad news is treated as a trust breach and appears on the performance rubric as one.
Meetings decide; dashboards inform	If it can be read, it is not an agenda item. If it cannot name its decision output in advance, it is not a meeting.
No surprises, in either direction	Nobody's number, review, exit or reorganisation should ever be new information to them at the moment it happens.
Predictable communication with partners	We publish the cadence and then we never miss it. Trust with a buyer, a partner or a lender is built by turning up on schedule with the same message and spent by going quiet. Silence is spending.
Say it once, to the person	Feedback goes to the person it concerns, first and directly. Anything else is politics, and politics is a tax the whole organisation pays.

6. How We Treat People

We tell you about the keeper test rather than running it in secret, because a standard applied quietly is a threat and a standard applied openly is a contract. Every quarter, in writing, every manager answers one question about every person who reports to them: if this person told me they were leaving for a comparable role elsewhere, would I fight hard to keep them?

The rule	What it protects
A "no" starts a conversation, not a termination.	One "no" quarter triggers a specific gap named against the scorecard, a written plan with 90-day checkpoints, and an honest conversation. Many first "no"s reverse — usually because the feedback had never been delivered clearly before, which is a management defect, not a performance one.

The rule	What it protects
Two consecutive "no"s is a decision already made.	At that point the organisation is not deliberating; it is refusing to execute. The two-cycle rule exists because we are all excellent at converting "not yet" into "never" when the conversation is uncomfortable.
Separation is fast, generous and honest.	Fast, because delay after the decision is pure cost and everyone can feel it. Generous, because every person who leaves becomes a permanent narrator of how we treat people. Honest, because the message is fit and trajectory — not a manufactured cause.
Every separation is root-caused as our defect.	Which interview signal failed, which reference was skipped, which scorecard dimension was waved through. The person is not the defect; the process that hired them into the wrong seat is.
Development above the floor is deliberately unequal.	The floor — a written scorecard, honest quarterly feedback, baseline training — is universal and non-negotiable. Above it, coaching, stretch assignments and early exposure concentrate on demonstrated compounders. Splitting development equally across everyone regardless of compounding rate is not fairness; it is a refusal to allocate.

CONSEQUENCE FRAMING

Carrying an unresolved people decision is not kindness to one person; it is a tax on three. The seat underperforms for every additional quarter. Your best people calibrate their own effort to the standard they watch you tolerate — nothing erodes a high performer faster than covering a gap while leadership pretends not to notice. And every month of inaction tells the whole organisation the stated bar is fiction. One operator's retrospective line belongs on a wall: "I thought I was being kind to one person. I was taxing three."

7. What Gets You More Scope — and What Gets You Exited

Scope grows when you	Exit becomes likely when you
Multiply other people's output — you build workflows, standards and agents that others reuse.	Deliver late bad news, or filtered reporting of any kind.
Hit your gates: pre-mortems filed and predictive, criteria written in advance, verdicts called on schedule.	Substitute narrative for mechanism — explaining misses with stories rather than with the driver tree.
Kill your own work on time and in public.	Fail the same gate repeatedly with no change to your process.
Say the number, especially when it is yours and it is bad.	Treat tooling and leverage as optional, so your output does not scale with resources.
Bridge a cluster the business cannot currently reach — capital, buyers, regulators, technical communities.	Re-litigate settled decisions outside the amendment process.
Change your position publicly on evidence, and name your own past errors with root causes.	Direct contempt at a person rather than directness at the work. Any compliance event.

8. Your First Thirty Days

#	Do this
1	Read the Operator's Manual end to end once. You will not remember it. That is fine — you will remember where things are.

#	Do this
2	Get your written outcome scorecard from your manager. If you do not have one by day three, that is a defect and you should say so.
3	Learn the driver tree for your part of the business well enough to draw it from memory. Everything else hangs off it.
4	Find out which metrics carry your name. There should be no ambiguity and no shared ones.
5	Sit in every forum in the cadence stack once, including the ones above your level. Ask what decision each one produces.
6	Read the last quarter of decision-journal entries in your area. This is the fastest way to learn how we actually think.
7	Read the failure archive before the wins. The kills carry more information and fewer myths.
8	Ship one thing in week one, however small. Motion is how you learn the cadence; observation is not.
9	Start the daily deposit immediately: one convexity action, one outbound contact, one asset. It compounds from day one or not at all.
10	Disagree with something, out loud, in a room, with evidence, before day thirty. We will take it seriously, and it is the fastest way to find out that we mean this.

9. What This Culture Is Not

Every strong culture gets misread in predictable ways, usually by people quoting it accurately. These are the six misreadings we expect. If you hear one of them in the building, correct it on the spot.

The misreading	The correction
"Directness means I can be brutal."	Directness is aimed at the work. Contempt is aimed at the person. We hire for the first and separate for the second. Delivering a hard message with respect is harder and is the actual standard.
"Bias for action means I can skip the gate."	Our speed comes from pre-cleared authority and short queues, never from skipped evidence. Skipping a gate does not make you fast; it makes you the reason the next three decisions run on narrative.
"Data over narrative means judgment doesn't count."	Conviction is sufficient authority to fund a pilot — that is written into the system deliberately. The evidence requirement attaches to the scale-up, where the money and the irreversibility are. Boldness and rigour are not at war; they are separated by a gate.
"Lean headcount means people are disposable."	The opposite. Refusing to hire around a missing system is what makes each seat consequential enough to justify the rigour of the hiring loop, the development ceiling and the pay. Disposable roles are the ones that exist to compensate for workflows nobody built.
"Kill fast means kill everything."	You kill your own work on schedule, against a number you wrote in advance. You challenge someone else's with evidence, in the forum that owns it. Casual destruction of other people's work is not rigour; it is a different failure wearing rigour's clothes.
"Speed means permanent crisis."	The cadence exists precisely so that intensity is scheduled rather than heroic. A business that needs heroism every week has an operating-system defect, not a commitment problem. If you are working weekends to hold the cadence together, something upstream is broken and we want to hear about it.

10. The One-Sentence Version

Say the number, write the criterion before you look, kill your own work on time, tell people the truth early, and spend your judgment on the things only judgment can do — and the system will do the rest.

What this culture removes is not discomfort. It is ambiguity. You will always know whether the business is compounding or drifting, whether a bet is a bet or a hope, and whether you have earned the next quarter of trust — because we will have written the answer down the quarter before.